Face-to-Face Interviews: The Gold Standard

- The face-to-face interview (also known as the in-person interview) is the oldest and most popular form of survey data collection. While technology has given us many new ways to talk, physically meeting someone remains the standard for high-quality research. It is a fundamental human exchange.

  We use this method specifically for sensitive projects. If you are collecting data on personal topics—like health issues or sexual behaviors—a digital form feels too cold and impersonal. An in-person setting allows for the necessary care, trust, and privacy required to discuss these matters.

  The goal is to meet an "informant." In research, an informant is simply the person giving us data. They might be a high-level expert, like a newspaper editor, or just a regular person deeply affected by the issue we are studying. We are there to learn from them.

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Why We Meet in Person

Face-to-face interviews continue to be the best **form of data collection** for two specific reasons. First, they **maximize the quality of the data**. When you are in the room, you can see if someone is confused by a question and help clarify it immediately, ensuring their answer is accurate.

Second, we must consider “nonresponse.” In research terms, nonresponse is the tendency for people to ignore your questions. It is very easy to delete an email or hang up a phone, but it is much harder to ignore a researcher who is sitting right in front of you.

This human connection is a powerful tool. By being physically present, you establish a social contract that makes it difficult for the participant to disengage. This ensures you actually get the answers you need to complete your study.

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The Rules of Engagement

Preparation is Essential
You cannot just show up and chat; you must prepare a set of questions in advance. This preparation shows respect for the participant and ensures you don't forget your main research goals during the conversation.

Respecting Time Limits
Interviews take time, and the informant is usually giving you their valuable time for free. Therefore, you should aim for the interview tc no more than one hour. It is important to set this expectation early so the participant feels comfortable.

The Quantity Rule of Thumb
Usually, 10 questions are enough for this amount of time. This helps you understand that you shouldn't prepare 50 questions. Deep conversation takes time, and rushing through a long list will hurt the quality of your answers.

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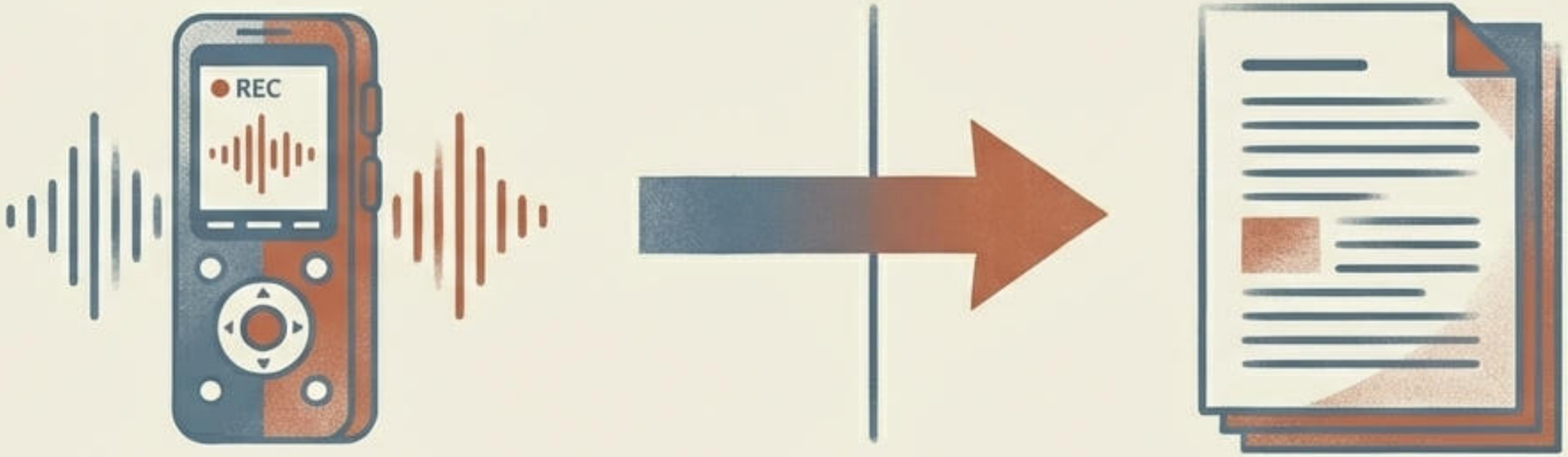
Capturing the Data



Recording for Accuracy

We always advise students to record their interviews. This allows you to check your facts later rather than relying on memory, which can be faulty. However, you should aso notes during the talk if you feel comfortable, just as a backup in case technology fails.

The Transcription Process

This leads to 'transcribing.' Transcribing is the process of listening to the recording later and typing out every single word said into a document. It is a literal translation of speech to text.

The Trade-off

There is a trade-off here. While having a full written transcript makes analyzing the results much easier later on, the actual process of typing it out takes a lot of time and effort. You must weigh this cost against the benefit of having perfect records.

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Research Ethics: Identity and Anonymity

Before starting, you must ask the informant if they are **prepared to be identified** by name in your research. Consent is the first step in ethical research.

In many cases, you will offer '**anonymity.**' To be **anonymous** means keeping the participant's name and identity **a secret**. This is usually necessary if you are researching a controversial topic or if the participant needs protection from social or professional backlash.

Offering anonymity often improves data quality. If a participant knows their name won't appear in the final report, they are more likely to share the honest truth about sensitive issues without fear of judgment.

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Closing the Loop

Once the interview is over, there is a review process. You may want to let your informant review any direct quotes you plan to use before you publish. While this is polite, be aware that it takes time and can sometimes delay the research process, so it is a strategic choice.

Always ask for contact details. You should ask the informant if you are allowed to include their contact information in the report. This allows future readers of your research to verify the source if necessary.

Finally, share the results. It is good practice to ask if they want to be alerted when your work is published. Tell them exactly where they can read the final report. This turns the interaction from a ‘taking’ of information into a generic exchange of value.

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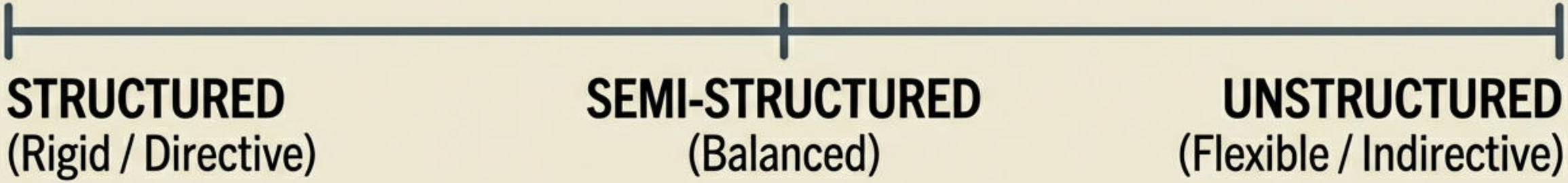
The Spectrum of Interviews



The Spectrum of Interviews
There is no single 'best' interview type. The answer depends entirely on your research design and what you want to accomplish.

The three main types—Structured, Unstructured, and Semi-Structured—**range from strict lists of questions to open conversations.**

Over the next three slides, we will explore exactly how each one works.

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1. The Unstructured Interview

Unstructured Interviews are ‘formless’ interactions that take place with few, if any, pre-written questions. They progress exactly like a normal conversation would, just focused on the general research topic.

Researchers use this style to establish ‘rapport.’ Rapport is simply building a friendly, trusting bond and comfort level with the participant. If the participant likes and trusts you, they will speak more freely.

This is extremely helpful for sensitive topics where a strict checklist might feel cold or interrogating. The researcher is expected to ‘probe’—asking spontaneous follow-up questions—to get the richest, deepest information possible.

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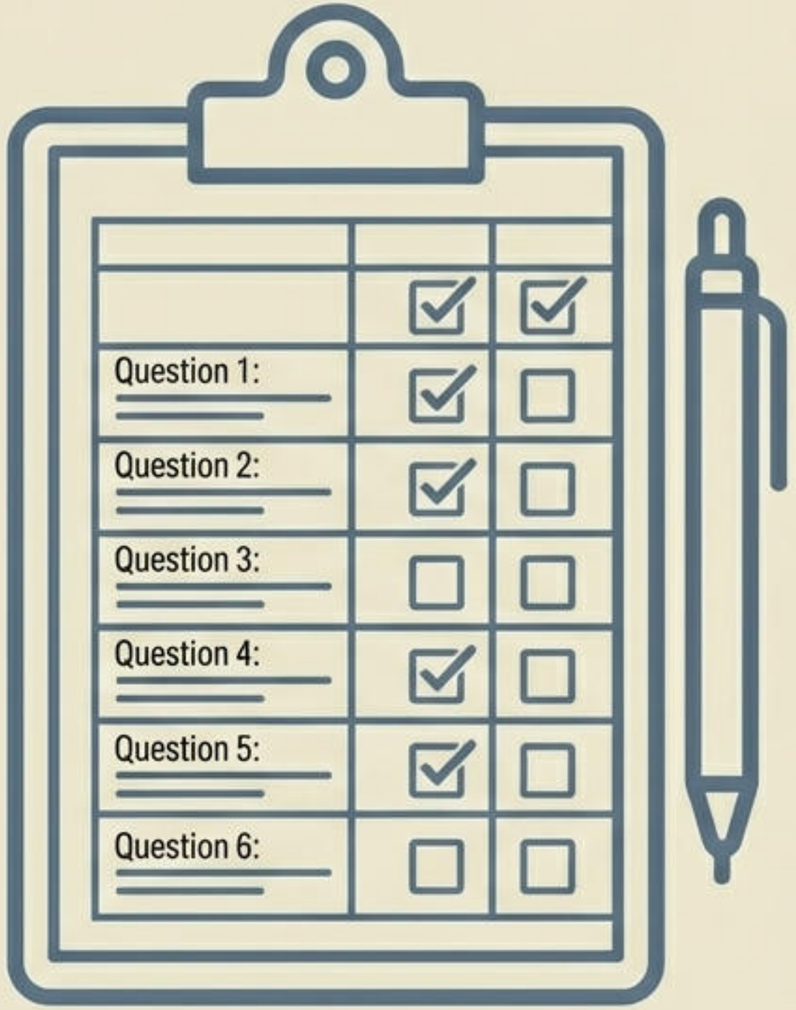
2. The Structured Interview

Structured Interviews are a rigid style where the researcher must strictly adhere to an ‘interview protocol.’ A protocol is just a technical name for a strict, pre-determined list of questions.

In this style, you only ask the questions on the list. There are not many opportunities to probe or explore new topics that the participant brings up. You stay on the rails.

However, this is advantageous when you already know exactly what you need to ask. It makes for “expedient” (fast and efficient) interviewing. You likely won’t need to do follow-up interviews because you captured everything on the list the first time.



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3. The Semi-Structured Interview

Semi-Structured Interviews are the middle ground. They use a protocol to guide the researcher, but it functions more like a ‘guided conversation’ than a script.

script. While it maintains some structure, it provides the researcher the ability to ‘probe’ the participant for additional details. Again, probing is just digging deeper into an answer to understand the ‘why.’

This offers the best of both worlds. You don’t have to worry about missing the basics because the protocol keeps you focused, but you still have the freedom to ask for more details about the participant’s thoughts, feelings, and opinions if something interesting comes up.

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4. The Deep Dive: In-Depth Interviews

The In-Depth Interview (sometimes called a clinical interview) is a qualitative technique involving intensive individual interviews with a small number of respondents.

The goal is to explore their perspectives on a particular idea or program to get a ‘complete picture’ of the problem. We aren’t looking for quick answers; we are looking for stories.

These interactions are usually unstructured or semi-structured and must be conducted by a ‘highly skilled interviewer.’ The purpose is to understand ‘underlying motivations’—the deep, complex reasons why people believe what they believe.

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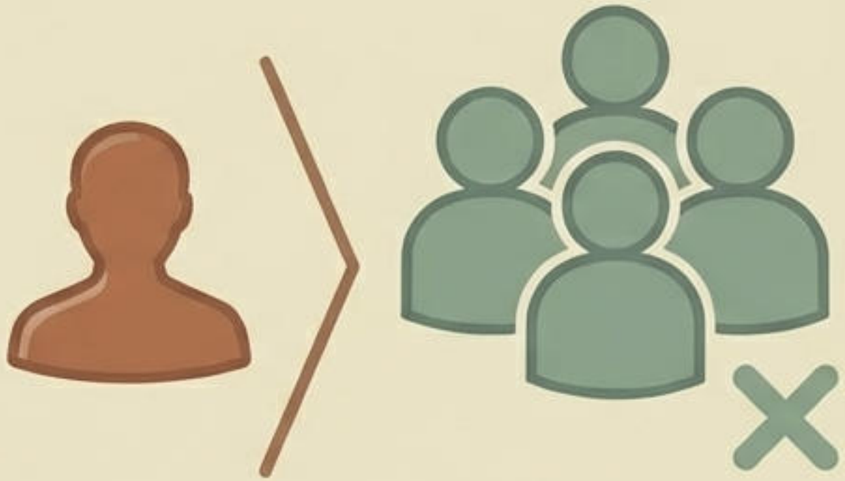
Why Not a Focus Group?

You should choose in-depth interviews instead of focus groups if your topic is highly sensitive. People may be uncomfortable sharing honest feelings about personal issues in a group setting.

In a group, people might be shy or fear judgment from others. A one-on-one setting removes this social pressure, allowing for total honesty.

There is also a logistical reason. Sometimes it is just too hard to get everyone in one room at the same time due to geographic distance or busy schedules. Individual interviews solve this logistical puzzle.



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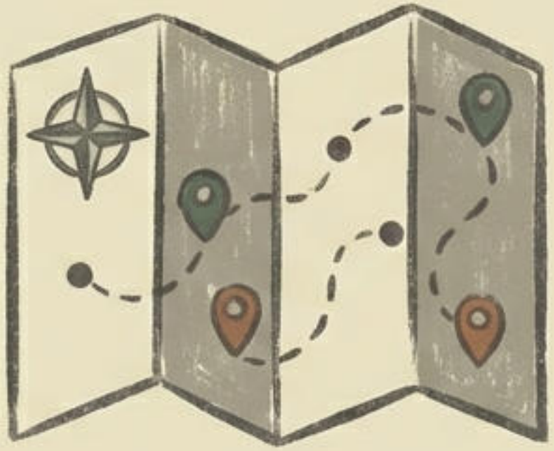
The Process: Planning Phases

Step 1: Developing a Sampling Strategy

This basically means deciding whose voice matters to your research and figuring out how you will find these people. You aren't just picking random people; you are picking specific targets who have the information you need.

Step 2: Writing an In-Depth Interview Guide

The interview guide acts like a 'roadmap.' It contains the core questions that will be asked, ensuring you cover the necessary topics while allowing for conversation. It keeps you from getting lost.



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The Process: Execution Phases

Step 3: Conducting the Interviews

This is the practical step of contacting potential respondents and actually sitting down to complete the conversation. This is where your interpersonal skills come into play.

Step 4: Analyzing the Data

This means ‘making sense of the findings.’ Since there are no numbers or graphs, you have Since there are no numbers or graphs, you have to read the text and find the patterns yourself. It is a mental puzzle where you group similar ideas together.

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Interviewer vs. Surveyor

Surveyor

In-depth interviews have more in common with a journalist's interview than a survey. Surveys use fixed questionnaires with scales (1 to 10). Telephone surveys might need 100+ people for a 'random sample.' You need to worry about being 'representative' of the whole population; looking for broad statistics.

Interviewer

In-depth interviews use a 'moderator guide.' Respondents answer in their own words, and the interviewer can adjust the order of questions. You are following the story, not the number order.
In-depth interviews often use as few as 10 to 15 people. You are looking for deep insight, not broad statistics.

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The Advantages

1. Depth

These interviews uncover valuable insights and allow you to find ‘the real story’ from the people who actually know it. You get the full context, not just a snapshot.

2. Disclosure

‘Disclosure’ means people opening up. Respondents are most likely to share honest, private details on a one-on-one basis compared to a group setting.

3. Speed

Surprisingly, data can be collected faster than other methods—usually within a few weeks—because you are only coordinating with one person at a time, rather than organizing large groups.

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The Disadvantages

1. Analysis is Hard

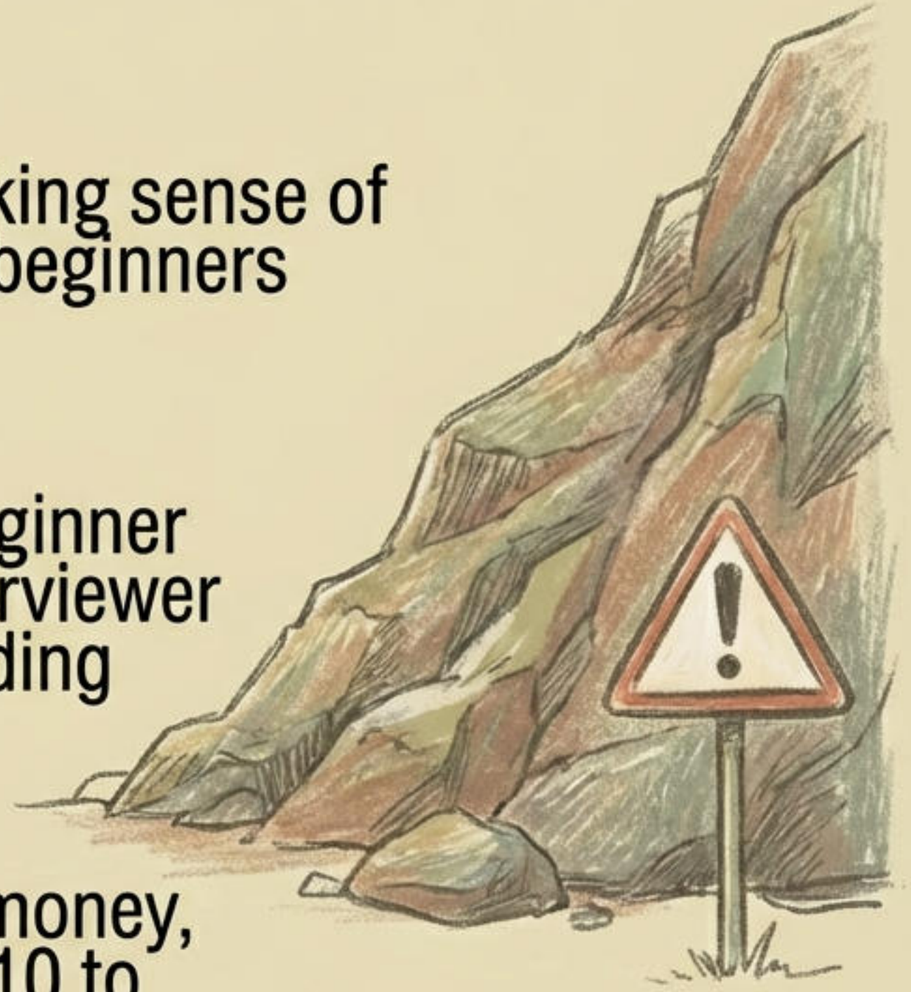
Qualitative data can be ambiguous (unclear). Making sense of pages of text is time-consuming and difficult for beginners compared to just looking at a number chart.

2. Skill Requirement

You need ‘highly-skilled interviewers.’ Using a beginner increases the possibility of ‘bias’—where the interviewer accidentally inffluences the answer by asking leading questions.

3. Small Numbers

Because each interview takes so long and costs money, you will only complete a small number (typically 10 to 15). You won’t get big statistics from this method.



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Soft Skills: The Art of Interviewing

1. Sensitivity: Research isn't just about the questions; it is about your personality. First, you need sensitivity. You must be able to read the respondent's mood and body language to know when to push and when to back off.

2. Active Listening: Second, you must practice active listening. You must have the ability to really listen to answers rather than just waiting to ask your next question.

3. Humor and Personal Experience: Third, try using humor and personal experience. These tools can help bring up sensitive issues or challenge a response without being rude. It makes the interview feel like a human interaction.

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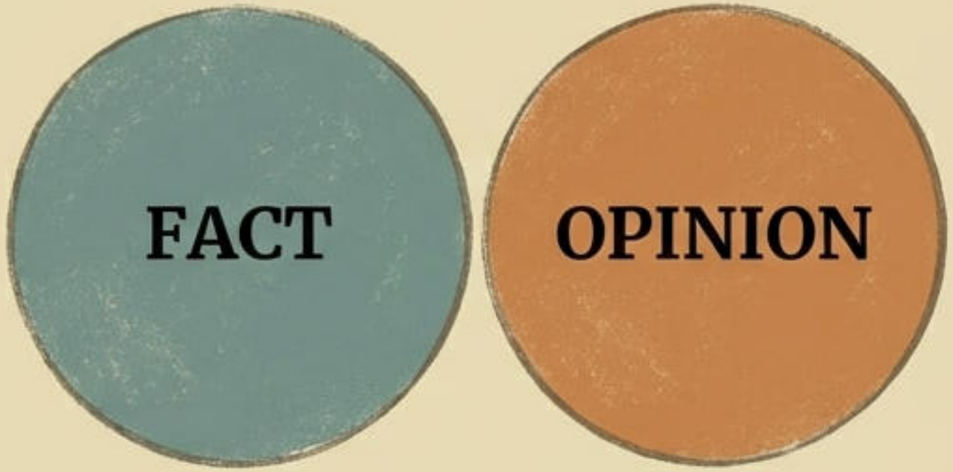
Documentation and Integrity

You must practice careful documentation. This means continually examining your own biases to make sure you aren't hearing what you want to hear.

When writing your report, as far as possible, quote the interviewee's exact words. Do not paraphrase unless necessary.

You must make it very clear where the participant stopped speaking and where your own analysis and interpretation began. Do not mix the two. The reader needs to know what is evidence and what is your opinion.



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Interviewing Cheat Sheet

The 3 Types

Structured (Rigid List)

Semi-Structured (Guided Conversation)

Unstructured (Formless Rapport)

The Process

1. Sampling (Who?)
2. Guide Writing (Roadmap)
3. Conducting (Action)
4. Analyzing (Sense-making)

The Trade-off

PROS: Depth, Disclosure, Speed

CONS: Bias Risk, Hard Analysis, Small Sample Size (10-15)

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